BOOKS

OUR DIGITISING SELFHOOD

In *Searches*, Vauhini Vara examines decades of digital progress and subjects tech capitalism to a social, moral and personal scrutiny



SEARCHES
SELFHOOD IN THE DIGITAL AGE
By Vauhini Vara
HARPERCOLLINS
₹599; 352 pages

Eczema. That's one of the first things author Vauhini Vara searched in the early days of the Internet, so early that Yahoo was her search engine of choice. That search assumed a special significance as I Googled my way through an eczema attack, searching every random piece of online wisdom.

In *Searches*, Vara trawls through three decades of technology, right from when there were just 10 websites in the world (imagine that), when Jeff Bezos and his wife had just started a business out of their garage (imagine *that*!). On the long, experiential road to ChatGPT, she sees the invisible webs that gird our digital lives: how social media is a site of performance by the "sanitised digital simulacra of selfhood", how online norms are resulting in subtle self-modifications, how technological capitalism is transmuting our very sense of selfhood.

Vara imagines a world where **TECH PRODUCTS** don't require exploiting others

This is a big book. Big in its ideas, its ambition, its formal daring. For starts, it's not a straight-up non-fic history of tech through a critical lens. It's a memoir of sorts, built like a double helix, with two intertwined strands: one strand is personal, pivoting around the early death of Deepa, Vara's sister. And grazing on her marriage, seeded in a series of missed texts. Another strand is technological, recording the problematic rise of surveillance capitalism through Meta's Zuckerberg, Amazon's Bezos, and OpenAI's Altman.

The two strands combine as Vara co-writes a chapter with ChatGPT about her sister's cancer and death. The chapter, also the book's emotional core, starts with Vara writing a single sentence in bold: "My sister was diagnosed with Ewing sarcoma when I was in my freshman year of high school and she was in her junior year." ChatGPT responds to the prompt with some anodyne prose. The back-and-forths continue, with Vara adding more and more of her own text in each prompt; by the ninth prompt, she is able to complete the story in her own voice. In her own words.

"GPT-3 couldn't satisfy me as a writer," notes Vara, for whom technological capitalism is both a promise and the perverse betrayal of its own promise. As she feeds each chapter to ChatGPT for its comments, Vara acknowledges the ambiguity in her own relationship with technological capitalism. "I could live without ChatGPT, but I don't," she writes, imagining a world in which tech products don't require exploiting others. It is this yin-yang of convenience and conscience, experience and ethics, that also makes this a big book—in its ability to embrace the ambiguity and paradoxes of the digital everyday. ■

—Bishakha Datta